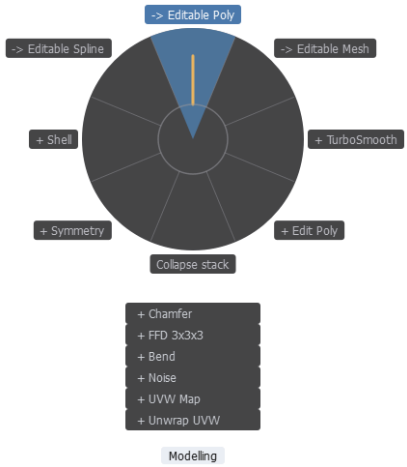
MarkingForge

QuickStart - the short version

3DS MAX 2027 · VERSION 1.5.52 · ABOUT 50 MINUTES



What you need to start: 16 short lessons in four parts. Everything else is in the full **QuickStart** and the **Reference** - **MarkingForge > Documentation** opens them.

Before you start

1. Look at the 3ds Max menu bar. You should see a **MarkingForge** menu.
2. Open **MarkingForge > Set up standard shortcuts...** It gives each dial its key, or says they already have one.

A dial is a round menu under a key

Hold Alt+1: eight commands appear around the mouse.

Aim, do not read

Move towards a command and let go of the key. Your hand learns the direction.

Nothing can go wrong

Let go in the middle, or press Esc: nothing runs. Ctrl+Z undoes any command.

About the keys: a safe start, meant to be changed

The dials come on **Alt+1..8**, **Ctrl+Alt+1..8** and **Shift+Alt+1..8**. These keys were chosen because they stay out of the way of 3ds Max's own shortcuts - MarkingForge takes none of them, and the setup skips any key you already use.

They are a starting point, not a rule. Put the dials you use most on keys your hand already knows - Space, a letter, a mouse button:

1. Open **MarkingForge > Menu editor...** and click the dial in the list.
2. Click the field **This slot's shortcut** and press the new key. The editor warns when 3ds Max or another dial already uses it.
3. Press **Apply shortcuts**. **Undo** next to it brings the previous keys back. (**Mouse button**, a little lower, opens the dial with a mouse button instead.)

This QuickStart names the standard keys - with your own, use yours.

PART 1

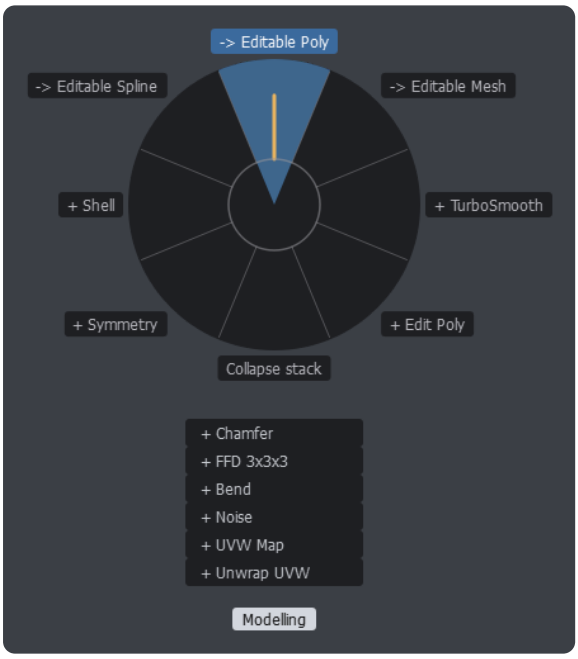
Using the dials

Five lessons. Open an empty scene and try each step.

1 Your first gesture

2 min

1. Mouse over a viewport. Hold **Alt+4** - the Create dial.
2. Move up to **Box** and let go. Drag a box in the viewport.
3. Click the box. Hold **Alt+1**, move up to **-> Editable Poly**, let go.



Alt+1, moved up: the box becomes an Editable Poly.

RESULT

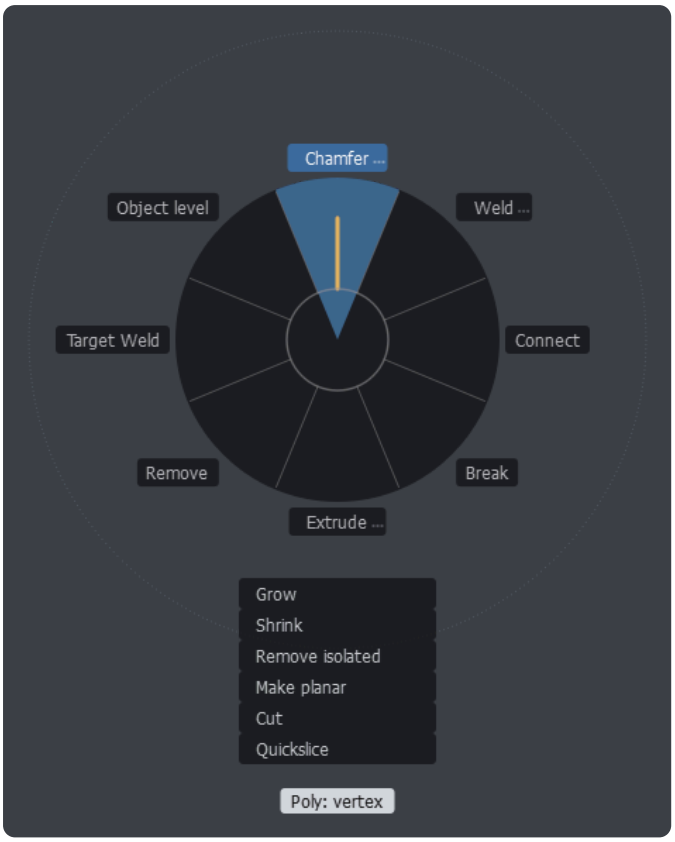
Two gestures, no menus.

2 The dial changes with your work

2 min

1. Press **1** (vertices). Hold **Alt+1**: now it shows vertex tools - Chamfer, Weld, Connect...
2. Press **4** (polygons). Hold **Alt+1**: Inset, Extrude, Bevel...

3 Move up-left (**Object level**) to go back to the whole object.



Vertices.



Polygons.

3 Flick - the fast way

2 min

Press the key and move **at the same moment**, then let go. The command runs and the dial does not even show. Try each one a few times:

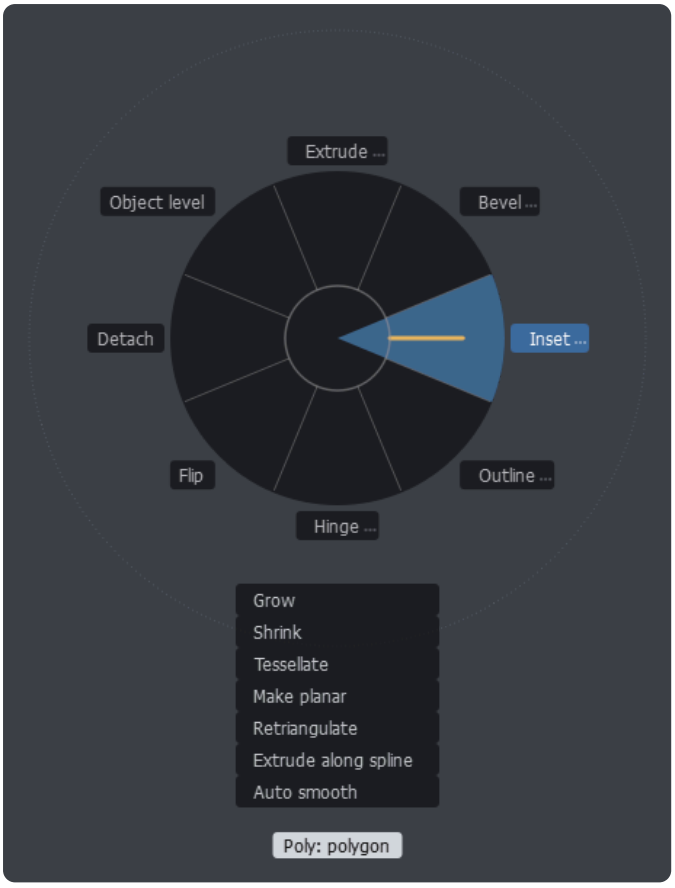
Press, then move	What happens
Ctrl+Alt+7, up	Zoom to see everything
Alt+3, up / down	Select all / select nothing
Ctrl+Alt+1, up	Move tool
Alt+7, up	Undo one step

4 Near or far: the dotted circle

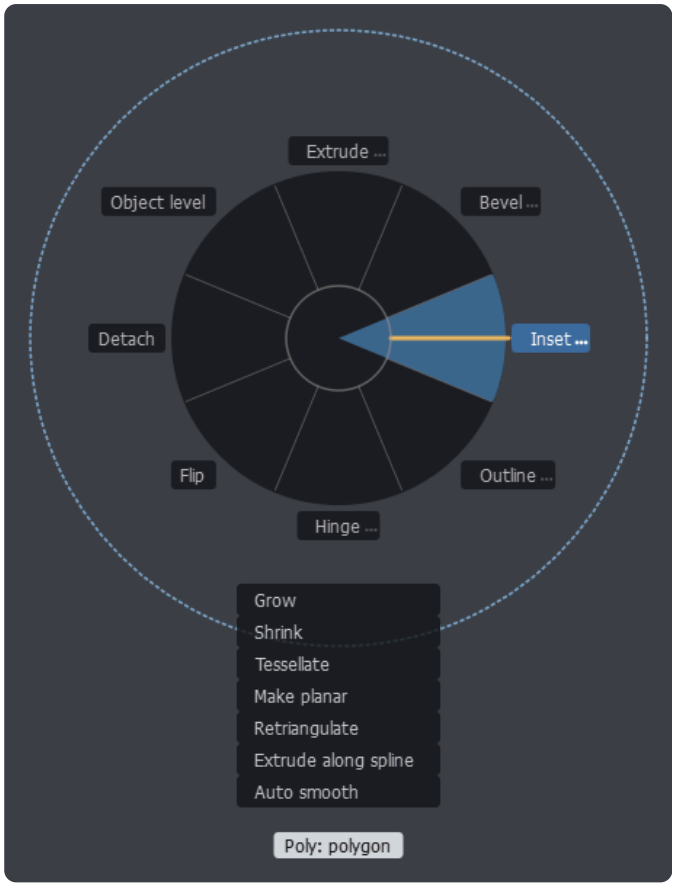
2 min

Commands with three dots (Chamfer..., Inset...) have a settings window.

- Let go **near** the dial: the command starts at once - drag in the viewport to set it.
- Let go **past the dotted circle** (it lights up): the settings window opens.



Near: Inset starts at once.



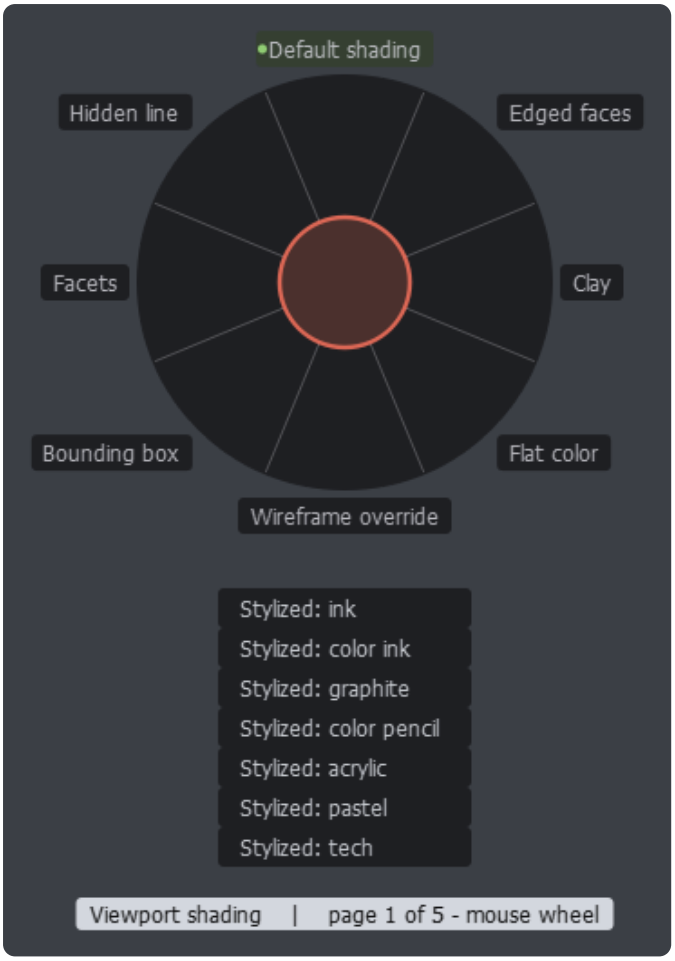
Past the circle: Inset's window.

---

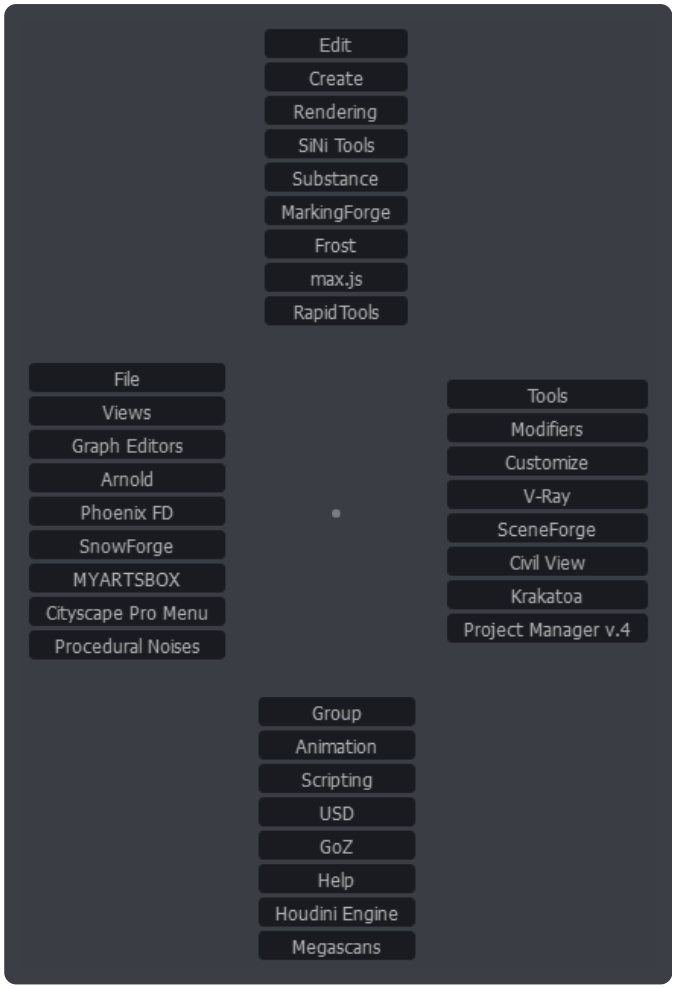
5 Pages, the hotbox and undo

2 min

1. Hold **Alt+5**: how the viewport looks. Keep holding and **turn the mouse wheel** - more pages (lights, what is shown, views).
2. Turn the wheel one step the other way: the **hotbox** - every 3ds Max menu as tiles. Esc closes it.
3. Hold **Alt+7**: your last steps by name. Pick one to undo back to it.



Alt+5 - the viewport.



Alt+5, wheel - the hotbox.

Which key is which

The number (1-8) is the place; **Alt**, **Ctrl+Alt** or **Shift+Alt** is the row.

Key	Dial	Key	Dial	Key	Dial
Alt+1	Modelling	**Ctrl+Alt+1**	Transform	**Shift+Alt+1**	Viewport display
Alt+2	Modifiers	**Ctrl+Alt+2**	Align and pivot	**Shift+Alt+2**	Selection sets
Alt+3	Selection	**Ctrl+Alt+3**	Lights and cameras	**Shift+Alt+3**	Materials
Alt+4	Create	**Ctrl+Alt+4**	UV mapping	**Shift+Alt+4**	Render
Alt+5	Viewport shading	**Ctrl+Alt+5**	Snaps and grid	**Shift+Alt+5**	Animation
Alt+6	Modifier stack	**Ctrl+Alt+6**	Show and hide	**Shift+Alt+6**	Scene
Alt+7	Undo	**Ctrl+Alt+7**	View	**Shift+Alt+7**	Tools and setup
Alt+8	Recent commands	**Ctrl+Alt+8**	Viewports	**Shift+Alt+8**	File

> Print your own list: **MarkingForge > Dial cheat sheet (HTML + PDF)...** - keep it next to the keyboard for the first week.

PART 2

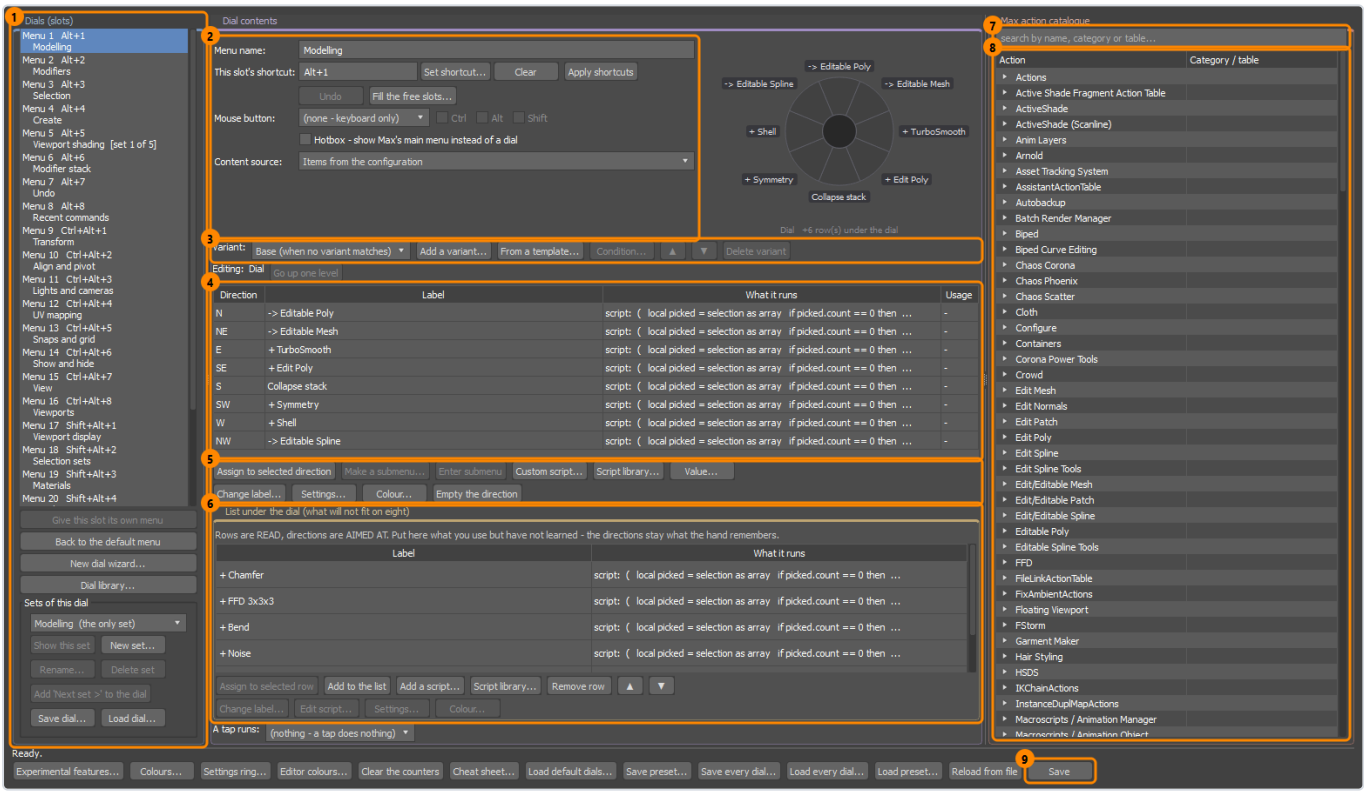
Changing the dials

Two lessons. Nothing changes until you press **Save**.

6 Open the editor

1 min

MarkingForge > Menu editor...



The menu editor.

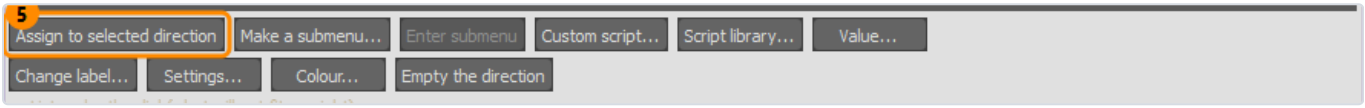
1. The 24 dials - click one to change it.
2. Its name, key and mouse button.
3. Variants - versions of the dial for other situations (lessons 8-11).
4. The eight directions.
5. Buttons for the selected direction.
6. Extra rows under the dial.
7. Search box.
8. Every 3ds Max command.
9. Save.

7 Put your own command on a dial

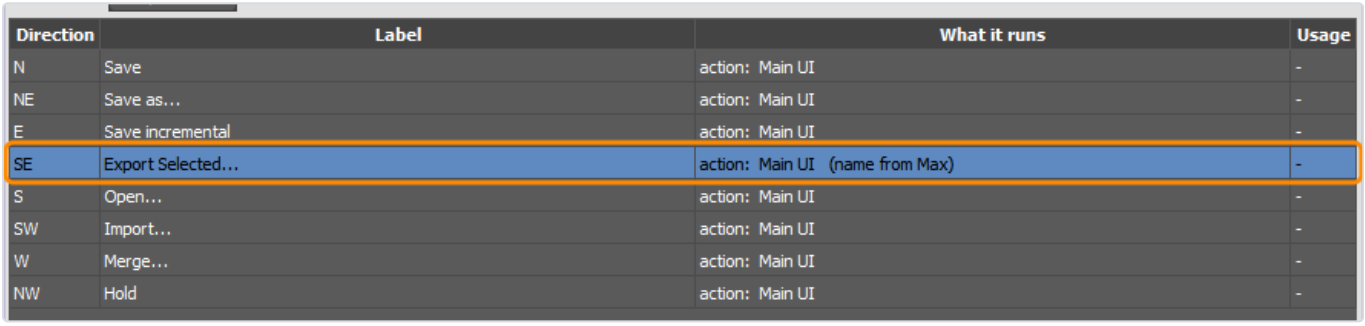
3 min

Example: on the File dial (Shift+Alt+8), put **Export Selected** down-right.

1. Click **Menu 24** in the list of dials.
2. Type `Export Selected` in the search box and click the command.
3. Click the **SE** row in the directions table.
4. Press **Assign to selected direction** under the table (or double-click the command).
5. Press **Save**.



The button under the directions table.



Direction	Label	What it runs	Usage
N	Save	action: Main UI	-
NE	Save as...	action: Main UI	-
E	Save incremental	action: Main UI	-
SE	Export Selected...	action: Main UI (name from Max)	-
S	Open...	action: Main UI	-
SW	Import...	action: Main UI	-
W	Merge...	action: Main UI	-
NW	Hold	action: Main UI	-

SE now runs Export Selected.

> **TRY IT**
>
> Hold Shift+Alt+8 over a viewport: down-right is Export Selected.

PART 3

Variants: one key, the right dial for each situation

Four lessons. A variant is the same dial in another situation - another object, another modifier, another window.

---

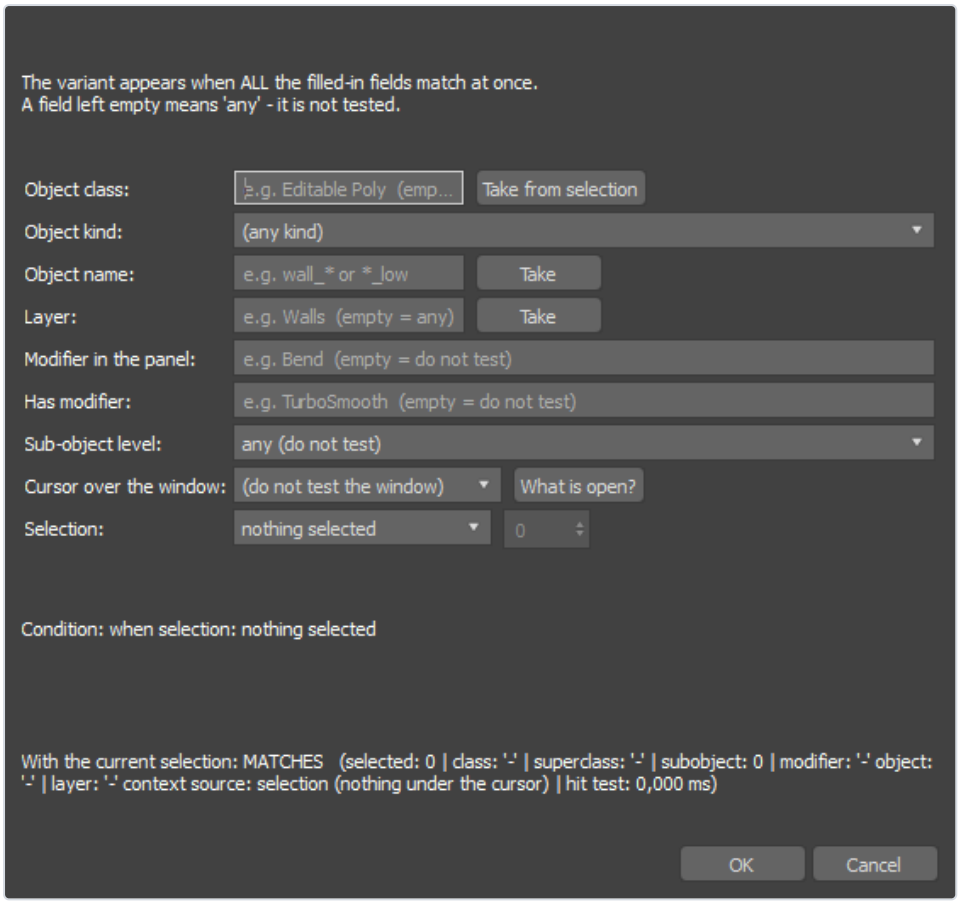
8 Variants: the dial changes by itself

4 min

In lesson 2 Alt+1 showed other tools for vertices and for polygons. Those are **variants**: other versions of the same dial, each with a **condition**. When you press the key, the dial shows the first variant whose condition is true - and its normal contents, the **base**, when none is.

Example: after lesson 7, down-right on the File dial is **Export Selected**. With nothing selected it has nothing to export - so let that direction export the whole scene then.

1. Click **Menu 24** in the list of dials.
2. Press **Add a variant...** - in the *Variant* row above the directions table.
3. In the window that opens, set **Selection** to *nothing selected* and press **OK**. The new variant starts as a copy of the dial, and the *Variant* list now shows it.
4. Type `Export` in the search box, click **Export...**, click the **SE** row and press **Assign to selected direction**.
5. Press **Save**.



Selection set to *nothing selected*. Fill in only what must be true - an empty field is not tested.

TRY IT

Click empty space in a viewport so nothing is selected and hold Shift+Alt+8: down-right is Export. Select an object: it is Export Selected again.

A variant can appear when...	For example
the object is of a class or kind	Editable Poly, any light
a modifier is open in the Modify panel	Unwrap UVW, Edit Poly
you are on a sub-object level	vertices, polygons
the cursor is over a window	the Slate material editor, the UV editor
the object's name or layer matches	wall_*, the layer Walls
this many objects are selected	nothing, one, two or more

To change the base again, pick **Base** in the *Variant* list. The first variant that matches wins, so a narrow one goes above a wide one - ▲ and ▼ move it.

---

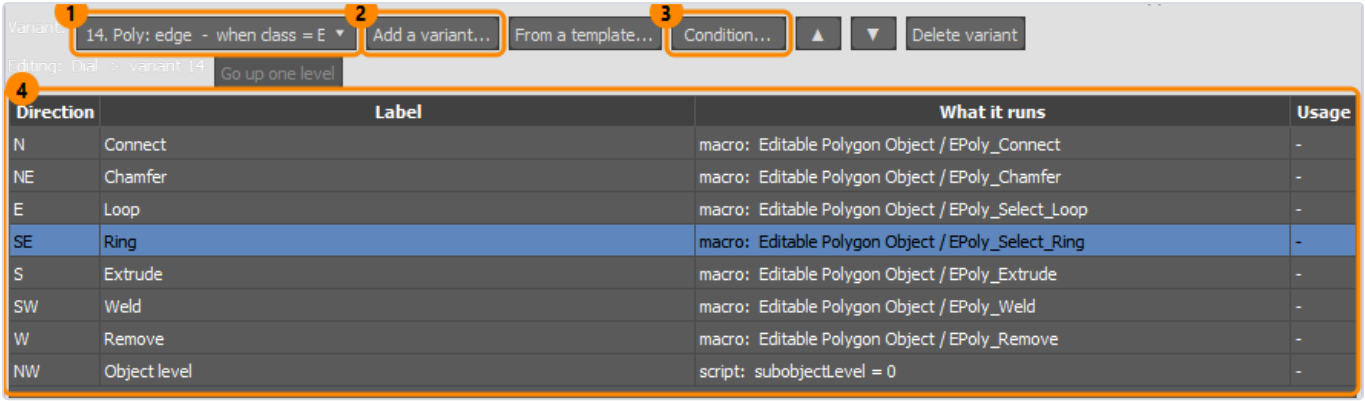
9 The variants that are already there

3 min

The built-in dials are full of variants - reading them is the quickest way to learn how they work.

1. Click **Menu 1** and open the *Variant* list above the directions table.

2. Pick a few and look at the directions table - and at the condition next to the name.



Direction	Label	What it runs	Usage
N	Connect	macro: Editable Polygon Object / EPoly_Connect	-
NE	Chamfer	macro: Editable Polygon Object / EPoly_Chamfer	-
E	Loop	macro: Editable Polygon Object / EPoly_Select_Loop	-
SE	Ring	macro: Editable Polygon Object / EPoly_Select_Ring	-
S	Extrude	macro: Editable Polygon Object / EPoly_Extrude	-
SW	Weld	macro: Editable Polygon Object / EPoly_Weld	-
W	Remove	macro: Editable Polygon Object / EPoly_Remove	-
NW	Object level	script: subobjectLevel = 0	-

The Variant list (1), Add a variant (2), Condition... (3) and the directions of the variant picked (4).

Variant of Menu 1 (Alt+1)	Its condition	What the dial shows
Materials (Slate)	cursor over the Slate material editor	material commands
Track View	cursor over Track View	key tangents, Flatten, Frame all
UV (Unwrap)	modifier in the panel: Unwrap_UVW	Quick relax, Pack, Stitch...
Edit Poly: edge	modifier: Edit_Poly, sub-object level 2	Connect, Chamfer, Loop...
Poly: edge	object class: Editable Poly, level 2	the same edge tools
Spline	object kind: shape	-> Editable Spline, + Extrude, + Lathe...
Nothing selected	selection: nothing selected	Box, Sphere, Select by name...

Why the order matters: an Edit Poly modifier on an Editable Poly object matches both *Edit Poly: edge* and *Poly: edge*. The list is read from the top and the first match wins - so the windows come first, then the modifiers, then the object classes, and *Nothing selected* last.

> **TRY IT**
> Create a box, convert it to Editable Poly, press 2 (edges) and hold Alt+1. Now move the cursor over the Modify panel and hold Alt+1 again: the *Modifier stack* variant - the cursor decides too.

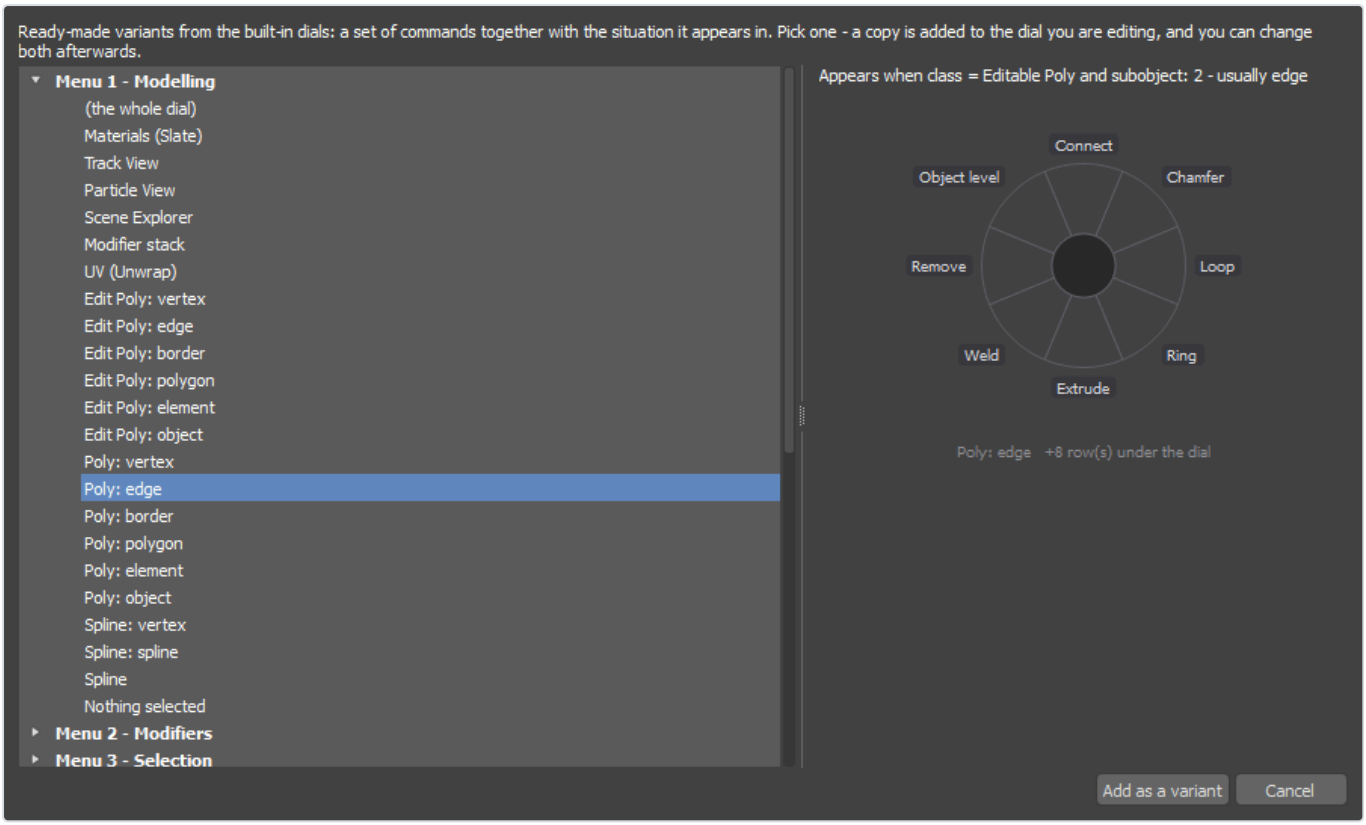
---

10 A variant for a window: Track View

3 min

The window under the cursor can be a condition too: the 3D view, the Modify panel, the Slate material editor, the UV editor, Track View, Scene Explorer, Particle View...

1. Open **Graph Editors > Track View - Curve Editor**, select an animated object, hold **Alt+1** over the curves: the Track View variant - tangents, Flatten, Frame all.
2. Now give the Create dial (Alt+4) the same: click **Menu 4** and press **From a template...** (next to *Add a variant...*).
3. Under **Menu 1 - Modelling** pick **Track View**. The right side shows the dial and when it appears. Press **Add as a variant**.
4. Press **Save**.



From a template...: ready-made variants of every built-in dial, with their conditions.

> **TRY IT**
>
> Hold Alt+4 over the curves: the Track View tools. Over a viewport: the Create dial as always.

For your own window condition, use **Cursor over the window** in the condition window. A window that is not in its list? Open it, press **What is open?** next to the list, and pick it there.

---

11 Object class, kind and modifier names

4 min

Three fields of the condition window ask about the selected object. They are easy to mix up:

Field	What it looks at	Example
Object class	what the object IS - the bottom of its modifier stack. An Editable Poly with a TurboSmooth on top is still an Editable Poly.	Editable Poly, Editable Mesh, Box, Line
Object kind	a wider sieve: every object of a kind, whatever its class. Picked from a list.	geometry, shape, light, camera, helper
Modifier in the panel	the modifier you have OPEN in the Modify panel right now.	Edit Poly, Unwrap UVW, TurboSmooth, Bend
Has modifier	the modifier is anywhere in the stack, open or not.	TurboSmooth

How to write a name. The name of the TYPE, as the Modifier List and the Create panel show it - not the name you gave an object or a modifier: a modifier renamed to *My unwrap* is still *Unwrap UVW*. A space and an underscore count the same (`Edit Poly` = `Edit_Poly`), and so do capital and small letters. The built-in dials write `Unwrap_UVW` and `Editable Poly` - both work.

Easiest: let the editor write it. Example - a variant of the Modifiers dial (Alt+2) for the Bend modifier:

1. Create a box and add a **Bend** modifier. Keep Bend open (highlighted) in the Modify panel.
2. In the editor click **Menu 2** and press **Add a variant...**
3. Press **Take from selection**. It fills Object class (*Box*), Object kind (*geometry*) and Modifier in the panel (*Bend*) - spelled exactly the way the plugin compares them.
4. Clear **Object class** and set **Object kind** back to *(any kind)*, so the variant works on every object with Bend open - not only on boxes. Press **OK**.
5. Put the commands you use with Bend on its directions and press **Save**.

> The line at the bottom of the condition window says whether the condition *MATCHES* what is selected now - check it before OK. Object name (with `*`, e.g. `wall_*`) and Layer work the same way, with their own **Take** buttons.

PART 4

Settings, chains and your own dial files

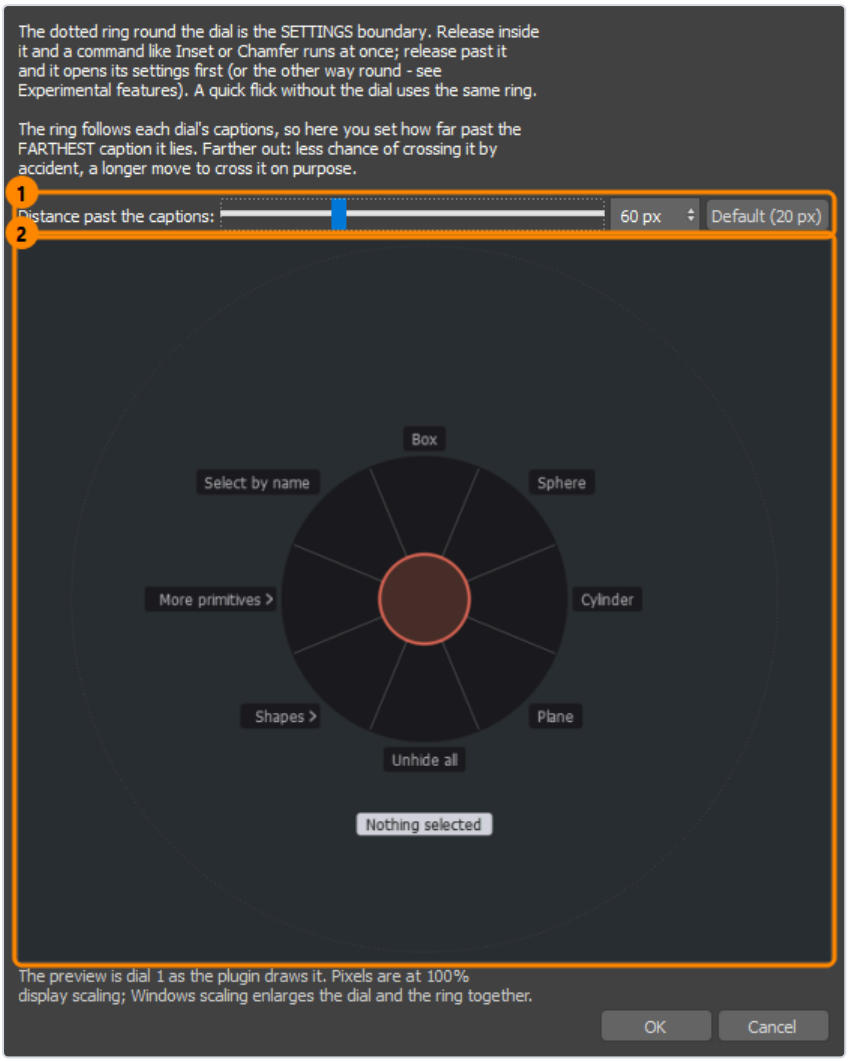
Five lessons.

12 The dotted ring: near or far, and its size

3 min

The dotted ring round the dial (lesson 4) is the **settings** boundary. Let go inside it and a command such as Inset or Chamfer starts at once; let go past it and its settings window opens first. A quick flick without the dial uses the same ring.

1. Press **Settings ring...** at the bottom of the editor.
2. Drag the slider (or type a number): the distance of the ring past the farthest caption, from 0 to 200 px. The picture is the real dial, redrawn as you drag.
3. Press **OK**, then **Save**. **Default (20 px)** puts it back.



Settings ring...: the distance past the captions (1) and the real dial with its ring (2).

- **Farther out**: less chance of opening a settings window by accident - a longer move to open it on purpose.
- **Closer in**: the settings windows are a short move away.
- One setting for every dial. The ring follows each dial, so it always sits just past its captions.

---

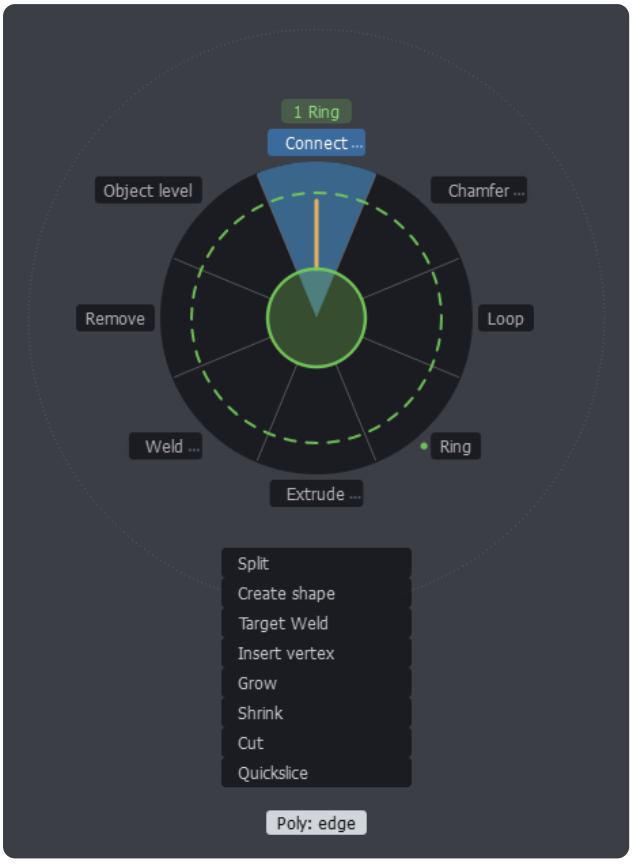
13 Several commands in one gesture

5 min

With one more switch, a single gesture can queue several commands and run them all when you let go - in order, and **one Ctrl+Z** undoes them all. A command that needs your drag (Inset, Bevel...) gets its own turn - lesson 14.

1. In the 3ds Max menu bar open **MarkingForge > Experimental features** and click **Multiple picks in one gesture** (it gets a tick).
2. Hold the key, move out **past the dotted ring** towards a command, and come **back to the dashed circle** near the middle - without letting go. The command waits in a queue: a numbered row above the dial.
3. Queue more the same way.

4. Let go **in the dashed circle** (it turns green): the queue runs, first to last. Or let go **over a command**: the queue runs, then that command.



A command waits in the queue (the row above the dial); the dashed circle round the middle is where you come back to.

Try it - a new edge loop in one gesture:

1. Create a box, convert it to Editable Poly, press **2** (edges) and click one edge.
2. Hold **Alt+1**: out to **Ring** and back, out to **Connect** and back.
3. Let go in the dashed circle. Ring selects the edges round the box, Connect puts a new loop through them. One Ctrl+Z takes both back.

In a queue	Why
Works: commands that finish at once - Loop, Ring, Grow, Shrink, Flip, Connect, Weld, Cap, adding a modifier, display and view commands, your own scripts	Each one is done before the next starts.
Waits for you: commands that need a drag in the viewport - Inset, Extrude, Bevel, Chamfer, Outline	The queue stops at it until you right-click - lesson 14.
Not queued at all: a submenu, a number slider, an Undo-dial step	There is nothing to run - the dial does not add them.

> Changed your mind? Let go on the dot in the very middle, or over an empty direction - the queue is thrown away and nothing runs. A queue you repeat can become one direction: **MarkingForge > Save last chain as an item...**

14 A queue that waits for you: Inset, Extrude, Bevel

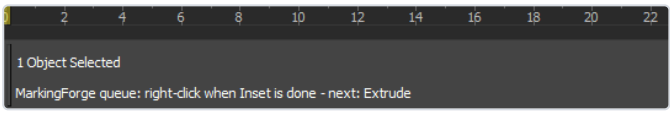
4 min

Inset, Extrude, Bevel, Chamfer and Outline do not finish at once: they switch on a tool and wait for you to drag in the viewport. In a queue each of them gets its turn - the queue stops at it, you do the drag, and a **right-click** moves on to the next command.

1. Switch on **Multiple picks in one gesture** (lesson 13).
2. Create a box, convert it to Editable Poly, press **4** (polygons) and click the top polygon.
3. Hold **Alt+1**: out to **Inset** (east) and back to the dashed circle, then out to **Extrude** (north) and back. The row above the dial reads *1 Inset > 2 Extrude*. Let go in the dashed circle.
4. Inset is on. Drag on the polygon to inset it.
5. **Right-click.** Inset is finished and Extrude starts by itself.
6. Drag up to extrude it, then right-click. Done: a new face inset and pulled out, in one gesture.



Inset (1) and Extrude (2) wait in the queue. Let go in the dashed circle.



While Inset is on, the status line at the bottom of 3ds Max names the next command.

While a tool is on	What happens
Right-click	The tool is finished; the next command in the queue starts. The last one is the command you let go over, if you let go over one.
Esc	Nothing - 3ds Max keeps the tool on. Right-click instead.
Pan, zoom or orbit the view	The queue keeps waiting.

Select, Move, Rotate or Scale (Q, W, E, R)	The tool is finished, as with a right-click - the next command starts.
Another tool (Bevel by hand, another dial command)	The rest of the queue is dropped.
Another object selected, one more, one fewer, or none	The rest of the queue is dropped (the status line says so).
You let go over a value direction (dragged for a number)	The number is written last, after the tool - or dropped with the rest.
A new gesture	The rest of the queue is dropped; the new gesture works as usual.

Ctrl+Z goes back one step at a time here: each command that waited for you is its own undo. Commands that finish at once (lesson 13) still run straight through and undo together. A queue that waited for a tool is not offered by **Save last chain as an item...** - as one item its steps would run straight through.

TRY IT

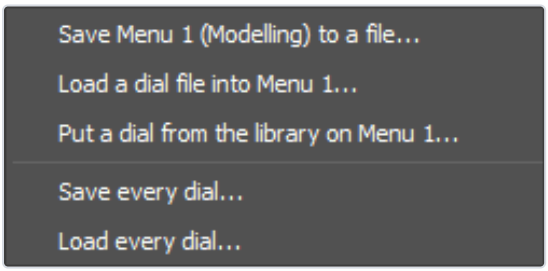
Queue Bevel (north-east) and Inset (east) on a polygon, then let go over Extrude (north): three tools in a row, each finished with a right-click.

---

15 Right-click a dial: save it, load it - or every dial

3 min

In the editor, **right-click a dial** in the list of dials (or its picture next to the directions):



The menu of a dial - right-click it in the list.

Command	What it does
Save Menu N (name) to a file...	This one dial, with its variants, in a `.mfdial` file - to keep, or to give a colleague.
Load a dial file into Menu N...	Puts a saved dial on this key. The other dials stay as they are.
Put a dial from the library on Menu N...	The dial library: every built-in, extra and pack dial, ready to take one by one.
Save every dial...	All 24 dials, their pages and their colours, as files in a new dated folder.
Load every dial...	Puts back everything such a folder holds.

TRY IT

Before you change a dial a lot: right-click it and save it to a file. If you do not like the result, load that file back into the same Menu and Save. Nothing else changes.

> Loading changes the editor only - press **Save** to make it work in 3ds Max.

16 Save, start again, share

2 min

Button (bottom of the editor)	What it does
Save	Your dials work at once.
Reload from file	Throws away what you have not saved.
Load default dials…	The dials MarkingForge came with. Tick *Replace…* to get all of them back.
Save preset… / Load preset…	Your whole layout in one file - to keep or share.

If something goes wrong

What happens	What to do
Holding the key does nothing	**MarkingForge > Set up standard shortcuts...**
I changed something, but the dial is the same	Press **Save** in the editor.
I want the original dials back	Editor: **Load default dials...**, tick *Replace...*, Save.
Where is the hotbox?	Hold Alt+5 and turn the mouse wheel one step away from you.
A caption is red	That command is not in this 3ds Max. Put another one there.
My variant never shows	Select it and press **Condition...** - the line at the bottom says whether it matches what is selected now. A variant higher in the list may match first.
My modifier variant never shows	The modifier must be OPEN in the Modify panel. Use **Take from selection** instead of typing the name - or **Has modifier** if it does not matter which one is open.
The dial is the same over Track View	The variant needs **Cursor over the window: Track View**, and nothing above it in the list may match first.
The next command of a queue does not start	Finish the tool with a **right-click** - Esc keeps it on. Another tool, another object or a new gesture drops the rest of the queue (lesson 14).

Want more? The full QuickStart shows scripts, number sliders, colours and more pages on one key; the Reference lists every condition and every window a variant can ask for.

Support, bug reports and feature requests

ISSUES	github.com/Forge-Plugins/MarkingForge/issues
ROADMAP	trello.com/b/7gJVqG8Y/markingforge-features-roadmap
E-MAIL	forgeplugins@gmail.com
WEB	https://forgeplugins.tech (forgeplugins.tech - more plugins by the author)

Bug reports and feature requests are best opened as issues on GitHub - the forms there ask for exactly what is needed, and you can follow the fix. Questions, and anything you would rather not post publicly (licence, purchase), go to the e-mail address. Every message is read.

Reporting a bug

1. In 3ds Max choose **MarkingForge > Report a bug...** - it copies your 3ds Max version, MarkingForge version, configuration summary and start-up log to the clipboard. It works even when the plugin did not load.
2. Open github.com/Forge-Plugins/MarkingForge/issues and pick **Bug report** - or write an e-mail to forgeplugins@gmail.com instead. Both are links in the window that opens (since 1.5.20), one click each.
3. Say what you did, what you expected and what happened instead, then paste the details with **Ctrl+V**.
4. Add a screenshot if you can. When the problem is in one dial, attach a preset of it (editor > **Save preset...**).

Suggesting a feature

Open an issue with the **Feature request** form, choose **MarkingForge > Suggest a feature...**, or simply write. Describe what you would like to do and how you do it today - a concrete example from your work says more than a list of wishes. Ideas for new built-in dials, commands and options are all welcome. What is already planned and in progress is on the **Roadmap** above - **MarkingForge > Roadmap (Trello)** opens it too.

Nothing is sent by the plugin itself: the details go to the clipboard and your own e-mail program, so you see everything that leaves your computer. MarkingForge has no network access.